

PMD · Project Selection & Kickoff Protocol

Artifact #20 · v1.0 · May 2026 · PMD System · Applies to every project P1 through Pn

PURPOSE OF THIS PROTOCOL

What this is	The structured process that fires before Phase 1 of every new project. It establishes the project's north star — the what and why — before a single artifact is drafted or a single line of code is written. It replaces the blank page with a puzzle. It converts activation paralysis into forward motion.
Why it exists	Without a kickoff protocol, every project begins with the same disorienting moment: scope uncertainty, tool setup anxiety, and the absence of a clear ignition point. This protocol eliminates that moment by design. The project does not start with a task list. It starts with a problem to solve.
The core mechanic	Puzzle-framing triggers intrinsic motivation by appealing to the problem-solver identity. The phase's skill and tool requirements are embedded inside the problem constraints — not listed as prerequisites to dread. The commercialization question adds a second ignition layer: every project is connected to real-world relevance from the first prompt.
When it runs	Once per project. Always before Phase 1 Discovery fires. The output of this protocol is the project's north star document — a single locked artifact that every subsequent phase refers back to.
Design principle	From JTBD Artifact #5, Design Principle 1: One prompt, one answer, one step. This protocol delivers exactly one ignition question at a time. The next step only appears after the current one is answered.

PROTOCOL OVERVIEW — FIVE STEPS

Step	Name	Who leads	Output	Time
1	Phase Context Brief	Coach delivers	Phase goals, skill targets, and tool set for this project's phase	5 min
2	The Ignition Prompt	Coach delivers User responds	Three project options presented. User selects, adapts, or proposes alternative.	10–20 min
3	Project Evaluation	Coach + User	Selected project scored against four criteria. Classification locked.	10 min
4	North Star Document	Coach drafts User approves	One-page locked north star: what, why, success definition, constraints.	10 min
5	Kickoff Checklist	User completes	Repository initialized, tools confirmed, content log created, Phase 1 ready to fire.	10 min

Coach
delivers

Step 1 — Phase Context Brief

Before the ignition prompt fires, the coach delivers a brief orientation to the current phase. This is not a lecture. It is a two-paragraph context drop that answers three questions: What capability does this phase build? What does the product look like at the end of this phase that it does not look like right now? And what is the single most important new concept introduced? The phase context brief is never a list of tools or prerequisites. It is a before-and-after framing: here is the gap, here is what closes it. The tools are mentioned only in the context of what they make possible — not what they require.

PHASE CONTEXT BRIEF TEMPLATE

Capability gap	Before this phase, the product cannot [X]. After this phase, it can [X]. That gap is what every project in this phase is designed to close.
The new concept	The single most important idea introduced in this phase — in one plain sentence. No jargon. No prerequisites. Why it matters to a real user or real business.
What it makes possible	Two or three concrete things the user can now do — or the evaluator can now see — that were not possible before this phase. Framed as outcomes, not features.

Coach
delivers
s · User
responses

Step 2 — The Ignition Prompt

We need to create a project that incorporates [phase goals and outcomes]. Here are three options that could work: Option A — [Project concept A] Option B — [Project concept B] Option C — [Project concept C] Which of these sounds most appealing to you? Do you have a fourth or fifth option to suggest? How could your chosen option be commercialized or genuinely help others?

IGNITION PROMPT — DESIGN MECHANICS

Why three options	Three options prevents the blank page. It also prevents false constraint — if none of the three resonate, the fourth or fifth option the user generates is always more owned and more motivated than a coach-assigned project. The coach's three options are seeds, not mandates.
Why commercialization	The commercialization question fires a second ignition layer. It connects a learning project to real-world relevance immediately. For someone with business fluency and product vision, 'how could this help others' is not an abstract question — it is an identity-level motivator. It also surfaces whether the project has portfolio potential early.

Why skill requirements are hidden	The phase goals and outcomes contain the skill and tool requirements — but they are framed as what the project must accomplish, not what the builder must learn. The difference is psychological. 'This project needs real-time updates across users' lands differently than 'this project requires you to learn WebSockets.'
What the coach prepares	Before delivering the ignition prompt, the coach identifies the phase and project slot, reviews the roadmap's scope and tools for that position, and drafts three meaningfully different project concepts that all satisfy the requirements. The three options should differ in domain, not just in name.

Step 3 — Project Evaluation

Once a project concept is selected or proposed, it is scored against four evaluation criteria before it is locked. This takes ten minutes and prevents building the wrong thing at the wrong depth. The evaluation is a conversation, not a form. The coach asks each question. The user answers. The coach scores. Both agree before moving to Step 4.

THE FOUR EVALUATION CRITERIA

Criterion	The Question	Pass	Fail → Action
1 Stretch Fit	Does this project require the new skills and tools identified for this phase position — without requiring skills from phases not yet reached?	Introduces phase tools. Uses prior tools as foundation.	Scope is too advanced: simplify the concept or move it to a later phase slot.
2 Stall Risk	Is the scope of this project small enough to maintain momentum — completable in a reasonable sprint without triggering the overwhelm loop?	Feels like a stretch. Does not feel like a wall.	Scope is too large: identify the MVP slice. Document the rest as a future iteration.
3 Classification	Would a hiring evaluator see this project and feel the problem it solves is relevant to their company? Or is this primarily a skill-building exercise?	Portfolio — evaluator-relevant problem. Shows on thepmddev.com.	Learning — internal only. Valuable but not showcased. Document the classification.
4 Commercial Potential	Is there a real-world user who would benefit from this product? Could it be monetized, open-sourced, or productized — even hypothetically?	A real person with a real problem. Commercialization path imaginable.	No clear user: rephrase the problem or select a different concept from the ignition options.

Step 4 — The North Star Document

The North Star Document is the single locked artifact that establishes the project's what and why before Phase 1 fires. It is one page. It is approved before any other artifact is created. Every subsequent phase refers back to it when scope questions arise. It is not a PRD — the PRD comes in Phase 5. It is the north star: directional, not prescriptive.

NORTH STAR DOCUMENT — TEMPLATE

Field	What to write
Project number & name	e.g. P1 · [Project name chosen during ignition]. The name should describe the product, not the tools.

The problem being solved	One paragraph. Who has this problem, what is the cost of not solving it, and why does it exist. Written in the voice of the user — not the builder.
The proposed solution	One paragraph. What the project builds and what it does not build. The 'does not build' line is as important as the 'builds' line.
Definition of done	Three to five specific, observable conditions that mean this project is complete. Not 'the app works' — 'a user can create an account, log in, and see their dashboard from a mobile browser without errors.'
Phase skill targets	The three to five capabilities this project is specifically designed to build. Framed as 'after this project I will be able to [X]' — not as a tool list.
Classification	Learning project (internal only) or Portfolio project (showcased on thepmddev.com). Locked here. Not revisited unless the retro produces compelling evidence to reclassify.
Commercial potential note	One sentence on who this could serve beyond the builder. Even a learning project gets this line — it keeps the product thinking alive.
Coaching mode	The calibration level for this project per the PMD coaching scale. Confirmed at kickoff, not assumed from the previous project.
Content log initialized	Confirmation that docs/content-log/ exists in the repository and the four Artifact-to-Draft buckets are ready to receive entries.

Step 5 — Kickoff Checklist

The kickoff checklist is the mechanical gate between the protocol and Phase 1 Discovery. It takes ten minutes. It is not administrative overhead — it is the moment the project becomes real. Every unchecked box is a future blocker identified before it becomes a stall.

Repository & Environment

- New GitHub repository created with project name matching the North Star Document
- README.md initialized with project name, phase, and one-line problem statement
- NOTES.md created — open items, technical debt, and deferred decisions tracked here
- docs/ folder created with subdirectories: current/ · archive/ · content-log/
- .gitignore configured for the project's expected tech stack
- First commit pushed — repository is live on GitHub
- Netlify or deployment target connected — CI/CD pipeline confirmed end to end

PMD System Files

- PMD_SKILL.md attached to session context (or confirmed in project)
- Current session summary PDF attached to session context
- North Star Document filed to docs/current/
- Four content log bucket files initialized: decisions.md · failures.md · metrics.md · user-insights.md

Tools & Accounts

- All new tools required for this phase confirmed installed or account created
- Any required API keys or credentials obtained and stored in .env (never committed)
- .env.example file created with all required variable names (no values)

Content Strategy

- Tier-1 Build Log post drafted for the project selection decision itself
- Post filed in decisions.md content log with competency tag applied
- Platform hook (first 100 characters) written and ready to publish

Phase 1 Ready

- North Star Document approved by both user and coach
- Coaching mode confirmed for this project
- Classification locked: Learning or Portfolio
- First Phase 1 Discovery prompt received from coach
- 'Too much' panic word confirmed active

PMD SYSTEM INTEGRATION — SKILL.MD ADDITION

The following rules are added to PMD_SKILL.md as a permanent process section. They sit alongside the coaching rules, nine phases, and content strategy obligations. The kickoff protocol is non-negotiable. No project begins without completing all five steps.

Before every project	The five-step Project Selection & Kickoff Protocol runs in full. No project begins at Phase 1 without a completed North Star Document and a passed Kickoff Checklist. This applies to P1 through Pn without exception.
The ignition prompt rule	The coach delivers three meaningfully different project options at Step 2. Options differ by domain and problem space — not just by name. The user selects, adapts, or proposes a fourth or fifth option. The coach never assigns a project unilaterally.
The commercialization question	Every ignition prompt includes the commercialization question: 'How could your chosen option be commercialized or genuinely help others?' This question is not optional. It connects every project to real-world relevance from the first prompt.
North Star Document is the scope authority	When scope questions arise during any phase, the North Star Document is the authority. If a proposed feature is not in service of the north star, it is deferred or documented as a future iteration. The PRD in Phase 5 expands on the north star — it does not contradict it.
Classification is locked at kickoff	Learning vs portfolio classification is decided at Step 3 and locked in the North Star Document. Reclassification requires explicit coach and user agreement and a documented rationale in the retro.
Reference artifact	Artifact #20 · Project Selection & Kickoff Protocol v1.0 · May 2026

VERSION HISTORY

Version	Key change	Date
v1.0	Initial protocol — five steps, ignition prompt pattern, four evaluation criteria, North Star Document template, kickoff checklist	May 2026

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